CHAPTER 2

THE DEMOGRAPHIC STRUCTURE OF THE INDIAN SOCIETY

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Examine demographic trends in India using formal and social demography, Malthusian theory, the three stages of demographic transition, sex ratios, age structure, dependency ratios, the demographic dividend, and national population policies.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Malthusian Theory and Demographic Transition:** Thomas Malthus posited that population grows geometrically while food supply grows arithmetically, necessitating preventive or positive checks; demographic transition theory identifies three stages moving from high birth and death rates to low birth and death rates through transitional population explosion.

• **Demographic Dividend and Age Structure:** India possesses a youthful age structure with a large cohort of working-age individuals (aged 15 to 64) relative to dependents; realizing this demographic dividend requires investments in quality education, health, and gainful employment generation.

• **Declining Sex Ratio and Son Preference:** The persistent decline in India's child sex ratio (ages 0 to 6) stems from systemic patriarchal biases, son preference (patrilineal lineage and dowry burden), and misuse of prenatal diagnostic technologies, leading to female feticide.

• **Urbanization and Rural-Urban Migration Dynamics:** Internal migration from rural hinterlands to urban metropolitan hubs is propelled by rural push factors (agrarian distress, unemployment) and urban pull factors (industrial jobs, educational infrastructure), reshaping urban spatial patterns.

ESSENTIAL SOCIOLOGICAL CONCEPTS & INSTITUTIONS

$$\text{Malthusian Imbalance} \rightarrow \text{Food Supply (Arithmetic: } 1, 2, 3, 4) \ll \text{Population (Geometric: } 1, 2, 4, 8)$$

Malthusian Disparity between Sustenance and Population

$$\text{Dependency Ratio} = \frac{\text{Population Aged 0 to 14} + \text{Population Aged 65 and Above}}{\text{Working-Age Population (Aged 15 to 64)}} \times 100$$

Macroeconomic Burden Formula on Working-Age Cohort

$$\text{Sex Ratio (India)} = \frac{\text{Number of Females}}{1000 \text{ Males}}$$

Standard Demographic Measure of Gender Balance

$$\text{Natural Growth Rate} = \text{Crude Birth Rate (CBR)} - \text{Crude Death Rate (CDR)}$$

Fundamental Demographic Net Population Expansion Metric

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** In India, the sex ratio is officially defined as the number of females per 1000 males, which is the exact inverse of Western conventions where it is defined as males per 100 females.

• **Alert:** Do not assume that the demographic dividend automatically guarantees economic growth; without massive expansion in vocational skills and decent jobs, a youth bulge can translate into social unrest and unemployment.

• **Alert:** Notice that India's population growth is currently driven by population momentum (large youth cohort in reproductive ages), even though total fertility rates have fallen near replacement level (2.1) in most states.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. Define Crude Birth Rate (CBR) and Crude Death Rate (CDR). [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Crude Birth Rate (CBR):** The total number of live births in a given year per 1000 persons in the mid-year population of a specific geographical area. **[1 Mark]**

• **Crude Death Rate (CDR):** The total number of deaths in a given year per 1000 persons in the mid-year population of a specific geographical area. **[1 Mark]**

2. State the core propositions of the Malthusian theory of population and mention two criticisms leveled against it. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Core Propositions:** Population increases at a geometric progression (1, 2, 4, 8, 16) whereas food production increases only at an arithmetic progression (1, 2, 3, 4, 5), inevitably causing famine, disease, and starvation unless controlled by preventive checks. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Two Criticisms:**
- Malthus failed to foresee rapid advancements in agricultural technology and Green Revolution methods that multiplied food output.
- European demographic history proved that rising standards of living and urbanization led to falling birth rates, contradicting his pessimistic predictions. **[1.5 Marks]**

3. Explain the three successive stages of the Theory of Demographic Transition. In which stage is contemporary India positioned? [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Stage 1 (Underdeveloped Society):** High birth rate and high death rate due to lack of medical facilities and poor sanitation, leading to low and stable population growth. **[1 Mark]**

• **Stage 2 (Developing Transitional Society):** Death rate drops sharply due to modern medicine and epidemic control, while birth rate remains stubbornly high, leading to a population explosion. **[1 Mark]**

• **Stage 3 (Developed Society):** Both birth rate and death rate are low and controlled, leading to low growth rate or stable population. **[1 Mark]**

• **India's Position:** Contemporary India is in the late phase of the second transitional stage, where the death rate has fallen substantially and the birth rate is declining rapidly toward replacement level. **[1 Mark]**

4. What is meant by the 'demographic dividend'? What socioeconomic prerequisites are vital to harness it effectively? [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Definition:** Demographic dividend refers to the potential economic growth that occurs when the proportion of the working-age population (15 to 64 years) is substantially larger than the non-working dependent population (below 15 and above 64 years). **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Prerequisites:**
- Providing accessible, quality education and industry-relevant vocational skills to young people.
- Creating productive, gainful employment opportunities and decent work in manufacturing and services.
- Ensuring universal healthcare and nutritional security. **[1.5 Marks]**

5. Analyze the causes and social consequences of the declining child sex ratio in India. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Causes:**
- Strong patriarchal preference for sons to carry on family lineage, perform funeral rituals, and inherit property.
- Perception of daughters as financial liabilities due to the oppressive institution of dowry.
- Widespread misuse of medical prenatal diagnostic technologies (ultrasound) leading to illegal female feticide. **[2 Marks]**

• **Social Consequences:**
- Severe deficit of marriageable women in prosperous agricultural states like Haryana and Punjab.
- Trafficking of brides from poorer regions (such as Assam, Odisha, and West Bengal).
- Escalating crimes and violence against women in public and domestic spheres. **[2 Marks]**

6. Distinguish between formal demography and social demography. **[Score: 3 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Formal Demography:** A quantitative mathematical study primarily focused on measurement, enumeration, statistical forecasting, and analysis of population components like birth, death, migration, and age structure. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Social Demography:** Explores the broader social, economic, cultural, and political causes and consequences of population change, examining how factors like religion, caste, gender, and poverty influence demographic trends. **[1.5 Marks]**

7. Elucidate the key objectives and strategies outlined in the National Population Policy (NPP) 2000 of India. **[Score: 5 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Immediate Objective:** Address unmet needs for contraception, health infrastructure, and basic reproductive and child healthcare services. **[1 Mark]**

• **Medium-Term Objective:** Bring the Total Fertility Rate (TFR) down to replacement levels (2.1 children per woman) by 2010 through vigorous implementation of inter-sectoral operational strategies. **[1 Mark]**

• **Long-Term Objective:** Achieve a stable population by 2045, consistent with the requirements of sustainable economic growth, social development, and environmental protection. **[1 Mark]**

• **Key Strategic Goals:**
- Making school education up to the age of 14 free and compulsory, reducing school dropouts.
- Reducing Infant Mortality Rate below 30 per 1000 live births and Maternal Mortality Ratio below 100 per 100,000 live births.
- Universal immunization of children against all vaccine-preventable diseases.
- Promoting delayed marriage for girls, not earlier than age 18 and preferably after 20 years. **[2 Marks]**